

good illustration of fortuitous parallel. Böklen (p. 58f.) quotes from the *Sad Dar*¹ a statement that a soul which on the Fourth Night proved to be deficient in good works might have the necessary amount made up by Mithra and Rashnu out of the works of supererogation accumulated by men of the good religion.² In later Judaism and medieval Christianity this doctrine makes its appearance, and as far as date goes the Parsi writer might be a borrower. But it comes very naturally out of the idea of weighing merits, which is fundamental in Persian thought. The *Sad Dar* theologian insists upon that doctrine on the very next page, urging that, if the sin outweighs the merit by the estimation of a hair, that person arrives in hell. He does not seem to remember the other statement, which would require us to believe that the treasury of supererogatory good works was empty. The oversight is due simply to the fact that the writer has a different object. When he tells of the works of supererogation, he is insisting that men must have no "hesitation and doubt" as to the superiority of the Religion to all other faiths, with its store of superfluous merits for the steadfast believer to draw on. His moral in the next chapter is that "even if a sin is trifling it is not desirable to commit it." If this conception should after all be old, there is no plausible reason for supposing that the Rabbis knew of it, and as little for the converse: we have only independent deductions from rather similar premisses.

¹ *SBE*, xxiv, 258: on its date see West's introduction, p. xxxvii.

² "This is to be associated," Prof. Jackson writes, "with the prayers for the soul as still made among the Parsis after the death of one beloved."